

Morning shower 65/48 • Tomorrow: Partly cloudy 70/55 B18

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, MAY 7, 2026 • \$4

Messages of faith by U.S. leaders poll poorly

Broad rejection of Trump and Hegseth statements, positive ratings for pope

BY MICHELLE BOORSTEIN AND SCOTT CLEMENT

Americans are deeply uncomfortable with recent religion-related statements by President Donald Trump and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth — a striking rebuke in a closely divided country, according to a Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll.

The poll finds positive ratings for Pope Leo XIV, who has criticized U.S. actions on immigration and in Iran, drawing criticism from Trump that the president repeated on Tuesday.

Eighty-seven percent of Americans have a negative view of Trump's social media post appearing to depict himself as Jesus, according to the poll. Sixty-nine percent dislike Hegseth praying at the Pentagon for "overwhelming violence of action against those who deserve no mercy."

Both expressions drew criticism even from Republicans and Trump voters, unusual at a time of deep political tribalism. Eighty percent of 2024 Trump voters had a negative reaction to Trump's Jesus post, as did 79 percent of Republicans. On Hegseth's prayer, more than 40 percent of both groups reacted negatively.

"There is only one Jesus! I found the posts to be inappropriate and offensive. Humility is at the core of being Jesus," said Kimberly Chopin, a 57-year-old Catholic who lives in suburban Baton Rouge and voted for

SEE POLL ON A2

Infighting at Kremlin signals rift among elite

BY CATHERINE BELTON

When Ilya Remeslo, a longtime Kremlin attack lawyer and propagandist, first turned against Vladimir Putin in March, posting publicly that the Russian president should resign and be brought to justice as "a war criminal and a thief," the Russian authorities rapidly carted Remeslo off — against his will — to a St. Petersburg psychiatric hospital.

But, in a highly unusual development for a regime that is notorious for incarcerating its critics for years, Remeslo was freed after 30 days. Now, the pro-Kremlin henchman and blogger, who worked for the presidential administration for about a decade smearing opposition activists, is vowing to remain in Russia and continue a public anti-Putin fight.

"I said from the beginning that I'm not going to stop," Remeslo told The Washington Post in an interview. "I decided that this is the work of my life."

As cracks appear in the Russian elite over the war against Ukraine, the deteriorating Russian economy and repressive restrictions, including limits on internet access, Remeslo's turn-about and continuing open defiance signify a broader divide in

SEE KREMLIN ON A14



IRAN STATE-AFFILIATED MEDIA

Left to right from top: Naval Support Activity Bahrain, Isa Air Base, Riffa Air Base, Erbil International Airport, Harir Air Base, Ali al-Salem Air Base, Camp Arifjan, Camp Buehring, Shuaiba Port, al-Udeid Air Base, Prince Sultan Air Base, al-Dhafa Air Base.

Trump threatens 'higher level' attacks

He dials up pressure for a peace deal as Tehran reviews U.S. 'framework'

BY KAREN DEYOUNG AND SUSANNAH GEORGE

A day after announcing a pause in the military's new operation to clear a path for commercial vessels through the Strait of Hormuz, halting a mission that had just begun, President Donald Trump on Wednesday threatened that if Iran did not agree to his latest peace plan, U.S. bombing would resume "at a much higher level."

Trump said Iran had already

accepted at least parts of the U.S. proposal as the two governments have continued to exchange documents via Pakistani mediators in recent days, expressing optimism — as he's done several times in recent weeks — that an agreement would be reached soon.

"We have to get what we have to get," Trump told reporters at the White House, expanding on an earlier social media post. "If we don't do that, we'll have to go a big step further. But ... they want to make a deal. We've had very good talks over the last 24 hours."

In Tehran, Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baqaei said his government was still reviewing the U.S. "framework" transmitted Sunday in reply to Iran's

latest 14-point plan. "Once our positions are finalized," he said in an interview with the semiofficial news agency ISNA, "they will be communicated to the Pakistani side."

Tehran had earlier rejected U.S. assertions that it had already agreed to concessions on the dismantling and future restrictions on its nuclear program. It said its proposal dealt only with the Strait of Hormuz, where more than 1,500 commercial ships are still waiting to get through Iran's closure of the critical waterway.

There were "absolutely no details regarding the country's nuclear issues in this proposal," Baqaei said Sunday as Iran began its review of the U.S. response. Iran had proposed nuclear dis-

cussions be postponed to a later date after the war was over.

A Pakistani official urged caution, saying the issues are "complicated." The official, speaking on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive closed-door talks, said the two sides were discussing a deal that would include lifting the U.S. blockade in exchange for a pause in Iranian nuclear enrichment and the easing of Iranian restrictions on passage through the strait.

Pakistani mediators pressed both sides to "differentiate between what is urgent and what is important," said Mushahid Hussain Syed, a former Pakistani senator who served on the foreign relations and defense committees.

SEE PEACE DEAL ON A13

Wide damage for U.S. assets

FAR LARGER THAN PUBLICLY ADMITTED

Satellite imagery exposes hundreds of Iran strikes

This article is by Evan Hill, Jarrett Ley, Alex Horton, Tara Copp and Dan Lamothe

Iranian airstrikes have damaged or destroyed at least 228 structures or pieces of equipment at U.S. military sites across the Middle East since the war began, hitting hangars, barracks, fuel depots, aircraft and key radar, communications and air defense equipment, according to a Washington Post analysis of satellite imagery. The amount of destruction is far larger than what has been publicly acknowledged by the U.S. government or previously reported.

The threat of air attacks rendered some of the U.S. bases in the region too dangerous to staff at normal levels, and commanders moved most of the personnel from these sites out of the range of Iranian fire at the start of the war, officials have said.

Since the start of the war on Feb. 28, seven service members have died in strikes on U.S. facilities in the region — six in Kuwait and one in Saudi Arabia — and more than 400 troops have suffered injuries as of late April, the U.S. military said. While most of the wounded returned to duty within days, at least 12 suffered injuries that military officials classified as serious, according to U.S. officials who, among others, spoke on the condition of anonymity due to the sensitivity of the issue.

Satellite imagery of the Middle East is unusually difficult to acquire at present. Two of the largest commercial providers, Vantor and Planet, have complied with requests from the U.S.

SEE IRAN ON A13

Pro-Israel consensus is collapsing in both parties

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF

Democratic congressional hopeful Dorothy McAuliffe fielded a poll in April with a question that rarely would have been asked in a Democratic primary race even two years ago: Should the United States cut off arms sales to Israel?

The poll by McAuliffe, a former first lady of Virginia, illustrated how the U.S.-Israel alliance has rapidly gone from a point of bipartisan consensus to a wedge issue dividing both parties. Almost half of Republicans (47 percent) and three-quarters of Democrats (72 percent) called support for Israel an issue that was causing problems in their respective parties, according to a CNN poll in late March. Some Democrats and Republicans alike are now campaigning on ending foreign aid to Israel.

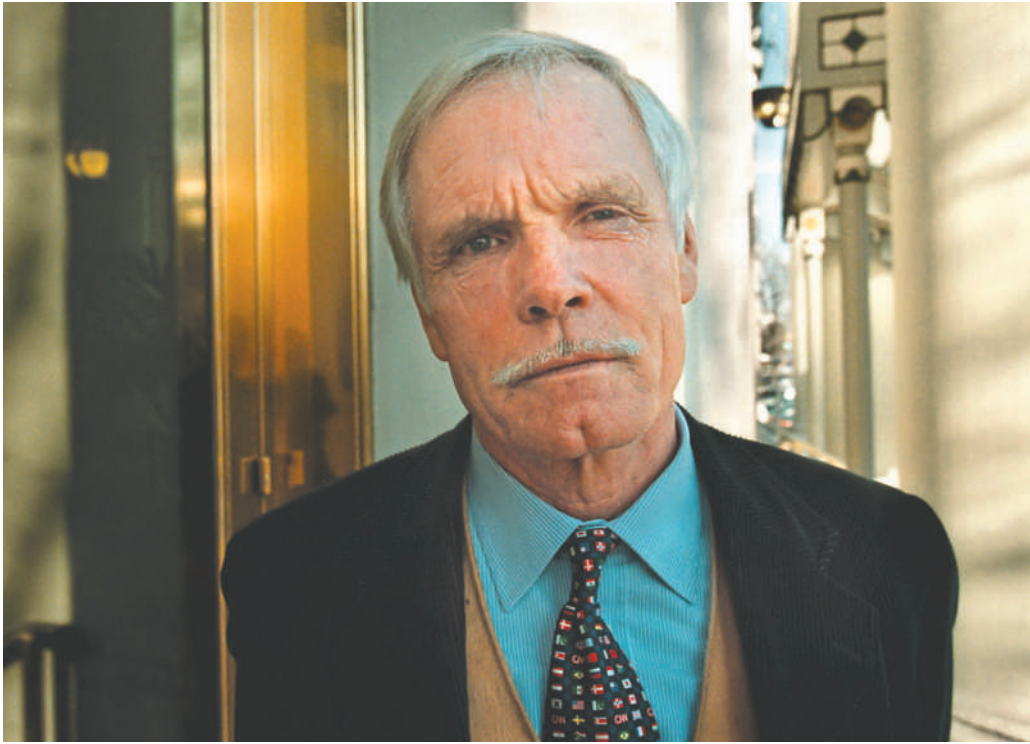
SEE ISRAEL ON A14

In Lebanon: Israel strikes Beirut suburbs, testing shaky truce. A2

TED TURNER 1938-2026

Cable TV visionary who created CNN

His sprawling legacy encompassed conservation, philanthropy and professional sports



MICHAEL WILLIAMSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

Ted Turner's bellicosity and bravado earned him the nickname "the Mouth of the South." His personality made him one of the most captivating public figures of his generation.

BY ADAM BERNSTEIN

Ted Turner, a mercurial tycoon and gadfly visionary whose "superstation" TBS was a cornerstone of cable TV's early success, whose 24-hour news channel CNN revolutionized TV journalism, and whose sprawling legacy encompassed conservation, philanthropy and professional sports, died Wednesday at his home near Tallahassee. He was 87.

His death was confirmed by Phillip Evans, a spokesman for Turner Enterprises. Mr. Turner revealed in 2018 that he had Lewy body dementia, a progressive brain disorder.

A serial entrepreneur known as "the Mouth of the South" for his bellicosity and bravado, Mr. Turner took over his family's Georgia-based billboard company at 24, after his father's suicide, and transformed the business into a media juggernaut that would forever alter broadcasting.

"CNN really heralds the world

SEE TURNER ON A10

IN THE NEWS

Vaccine research The FDA has stopped the publication of studies on the safety of covid-19 and shingles vaccines in recent months, saying the conclusions were unsupported. A3

Higher standards Immigration and Customs Enforcement will return to a longer training program for new deportation officers. A4

THE NATION A Texas man has been charged after shots were fired near JD Vance's motorcade in D.C. A3
Primaries in Indiana and Ohio reinforced Donald Trump's power over the GOP. A4

THE WORLD Contact tracing is underway following a hantavirus outbreak aboard a cruise ship. A12

CLIMATE The world is bracing for the strongest El Niño in over a century. A6

THE ECONOMY Elon Musk will settle with the SEC over allegations he failed to disclose a large purchase of Twitter shares before his acquisition. A18
The FDA approved fruit-flavored vapes for adults after President Trump vowed to "save" electronic cigarettes. A18

STYLE For these parents, processing their grief over their daughter's death meant telling Miranda's story. B1

SPORTS The WNBA is set for a historic 30th season after a transformational new collective bargaining agreement. B7

THE REGION A Virginia woman who distributed leaflets with the home address of Stephen Miller won't face state charges. B13

LOCAL LIVING Put the TikTok advice aside: Here's a no-muss, no-fuss routine that will get your bathroom clean in no time at all.

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